

Correct breathing maximizes the oxygen available. When you breathe out, feel the rib cage relax (inset); when you breathe in, feel it expand upward and sideways.

body naturally sweats to cool itself. Sipping water while you are exercising will replenish the fluid you lose through sweating. So before you start, make sure you have a glass conveniently placed nearby.

Correct breathing

Breathing properly during aerobic activity ensures the lungs and heart get enough oxygen to supply the rest of the body. Think of breathing deeply and fully all the time and practice by placing your hands on the sides of your rib cage. As you inhale, slowly feel your ribs expand to the front, sides, and back. As you exhale, feel your rib cage soften as the muscles relax and the air is expelled.

How often and when should I perform these workouts?

Since these workouts last only around 15 minutes, they should easily fit into anyone's day. They can be performed at the beginning, middle, or end of your day, though I recommend exercising in the morning. This not only gets it out of the way, but you feel great for the rest of the day, too.

Try to do one of the workouts at least three times a week. Make a firm commitment to yourself to set aside regular time just for your dance. Once you get into the habit, you will feel better, and more energized and toned for everything else you do.

Counting the eights

Counting music is easy. Music is divided into regular, rhythmic beats grouped in phrases. All the music for these workouts is written in eight-count phrases. When you first perform a movement, you will repeat it for four eight-count phrases, which gives you a chance to get used to doing it. As you start to come down the aerobic curve (see p.188), you only repeat the movements for two eight-count phrases. But if you ever have trouble finding the beat of the music, don't worry. All you need to do is follow along with the DVD.



>> some safety guidelines

Exercising safely is key. Proper alignment and technique will help keep you strong and healthy now and in years to come, as your program becomes more advanced.

- **Whether your knees are bent or straight,** make sure they are always in a direct line with your toes. If the line of the knee is on the inside or outside of the foot, it places unnecessary strain on the knee joint.
- **Keep your knees soft.** Landing on a stiff leg can not only jar the body, but can also damage the joints.
- **When you jump,** think of rolling through the feet, starting from the toes, then the arches, and finally the heels.
- **Always think** of pulling your tummy in and lengthening your tailbone down toward the ground. This stops you from arching your back, which puts too much strain on the muscles supporting your spine and can damage the spinal column.